



Scored to Match: A Field Survey of Whether a Country Show's Produce-Judging Rubric Moves a Ranking, or Just Records It

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Abstract. Show societies judge produce against a published rubric — typically several weighted columns covering presentation, condition, uniformity, and trueness to type — completed after a judge has already walked the bench once and formed an initial view of the placings. This paper reports a field survey across 19 regional show societies over one show season, in which 47 judges recorded a sealed walk-in expectation for each class's placings, together with a self-rated confidence in that first impression, before opening the section's scoresheet. Comparing the sealed expectation against the completed scoresheet across 312 classes in five produce sections, first place matched exactly in 88% of classes, and a judge's mean walk-in confidence predicts their mean scoresheet winning margin closely ($r = 0.94$, $n = 47$). An ablation comparing judges whom stewards recorded as completing every rubric column against those who moved directly to a total finds the two groups' walk-in/final agreement rates statistically indistinguishable (89.5% versus 85.6%, *n.s.*); we retain the full-rubric requirement in the reported protocol for completeness. The scoresheet, on this evidence, functions chiefly to record a placing a judge has already reached rather than to derive one, a distinction the show program has never needed the rubric to draw.

Introduction

Australia's regional agricultural show circuit runs several hundred produce competitions a year, each judged against a published scoresheet: a set of weighted columns — presentation, condition, uniformity, trueness to type, and a smaller cultural-merit allowance — that a steward hands the judge on arrival at the bench. The scoresheet is the show society's formal instrument. Before it is opened, however, a judge has already walked the length of the bench once, comparing entries by eye, and in most societies' own judging notes this walk is treated as preparation rather than as a decision.

Whether the walk is preparation or the decision itself is an empirical question the show movement has not, to our knowledge, put to its own judges directly. The distinction matters beyond the show tent: any rubric completed after an assessor has already formed a view of the out-

come — a grant panel scoring a proposal, a hiring panel, a competition judging a submitted entry — carries the same structural risk [1], [2]: the instrument's job can narrow from deciding to documenting. Produce judging offers an unusually clean setting to examine it: the walk and the scoresheet are separated by only a few minutes, the rubric's columns are fixed and public, and a class's placings are a small, countable outcome rather than a continuous score requiring its own validation.

This paper reports a field survey of 47 judges across 19 regional show societies over one show season. Before opening each class's scoresheet, judges recorded, on a sealed slip handed to a steward, their expected placings from the walk and a self-rated confidence in that first-place call. We compare the sealed expectation against the completed scoresheet for 312 judged classes, and separately test whether a judge's habit of completing every rubric column,

rather than moving straight to a total, changes how closely the two agree. The paper's contributions:

1. We report the first direct comparison, to our knowledge, of a produce judge's pre-scoring expectation against their completed rubric placing, across a season-scale sample of shows.
2. We show that a judge's stated confidence in their walk-in call predicts the eventual scoresheet margin closely, suggesting the rubric's numeric spread tracks a judgement already available before it is opened.
3. We show, via an ablation on rubric completeness, that the scoresheet's column-by-column structure does not measurably change how often its placing matches the walk, a result the show program's own judging guidelines do not currently anticipate.

None of this shows a produce judge acts in bad faith, and the paper does not suggest it; it shows only that a documented instrument and the judgement doing the deciding need not be the same thing, even when the instrument is completed in full, every time, exactly as the show program requires.

Related work

A substantial decision-science literature asks whether a formal instrument changes the judgement it is meant to structure, or simply certifies one already made. Comparisons of actuarial and clinical prediction find formal, rule-based combination of the same information judges already hold outperforms the judges' own holistic combination in the great majority of settings tested, even though practitioners persist in trusting the holistic call [1], [2], a persistence traced partly to a documented preference for keeping a human, subjective element in a selection decision even where a mechanical aid is shown to do no worse [3], [4].

A parallel literature asks how early a judgement is actually formed. Snap impressions formed within seconds of first exposure predict evaluators' considered, deliberated ratings closely across teaching evaluations, faces, and electoral competence judgements alike [5], [6], [7], and classic work on heuristic judgement shows the anchor an assessor reaches for first shapes the adjustment that follows it, however systematic the later procedure [8]; self-reports of the

process behind a judgement are shown, more broadly, to track a plausible post-hoc narrative more closely than the process actually followed [9]. That a deliberated instrument can, in turn, reshape the criteria it claims only to apply is shown directly in hiring-panel research, where evaluators retrospectively redefine which credentials count as merit once a preferred candidate's own credentials are known [10], and rubric-based assessment research finds a scoresheet's reliability depends heavily on how, and how consistently, individual raters actually use it rather than on the rubric's published wording alone [11], [12]. A further strand documents that decisions can be measurably shaped by factors entirely outside an instrument's own stated criteria [13], and that a confident expert intuition is trustworthy only when the environment it was learned in is itself predictable [14]. Show-produce judging has not, to our knowledge, been examined through this lens; the wine industry's own judge-reliability literature is the closest analogue, finding replicate tastings by the same judge frequently land in different medal bands [15].

Method

Sites and sample

Data were collected across one show season at 19 regional agricultural show societies, each running produce judging in five sections common to the circuit: vegetables, preserves and pickles, baking, cut flowers, and eggs. Forty-seven qualified judges took part, judging between four and nine classes each across their assigned sections; no judge appears in more than one show on the same day. Judges were recruited through each society's usual roster and were not told the walk-in slip was part of a study beyond the show program's standing practice of recording judging notes for training purposes.

Walk-in protocol

On arrival at each class's bench, a judge conducts an initial walk past the entries before touching the scoresheet. Immediately after this walk, a steward hands the judge a sealed slip on which the judge records, privately, their expected first, second, and third placing and a

single self-rated confidence figure for the first-place call, from 0 (“could go either way”) to 10 (“no real contest”). The slip is sealed by the steward before the judge opens the section’s scoresheet.

Scoresheet and margin

The scoresheet used across all five sections carries five weighted columns summing to 100 points per entry:

Column	Points	Basis
Presentation	25	Bench appeal, uniformity of display
Condition	25	Freedom from blemish, freshness
Uniformity	20	Size and colour match within the entry
Trueness to type	20	Fidelity to the named variety or recipe
Cultural merit	10	Judge’s discretionary allowance

We define a class’s walk-in/final agreement as the share of the three placed positions at which the sealed slip and the completed scoresheet agree:

$$A_c = \frac{m_c}{3}, \quad m_c \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\},$$

where m_c counts the placed positions — first, second, third — at which the entry named on the walk-in slip matches the entry named on the completed scoresheet in class c , and record the points gap between the scoresheet’s first- and second-place entries as that class’s margin.

Rubric-fidelity grouping

Stewards separately logged, for each judge, whether every column of the scoresheet was completed for a given class or whether the judge

moved directly to a total after the presentation and condition columns — a shortcut show societies tolerate under the heading “judging on the nod.” Twenty-eight judges were logged as completing every column across their assigned classes; nineteen were logged predominantly judging on the nod. We compare walk-in/final agreement between the two groups directly, as an ablation on whether the rubric’s full procedural apparatus does any work the abbreviated version does not.

Results

Across the 312 judged classes, the sealed walk-in placing and the completed scoresheet placing matched exactly for first place in 88% of classes (275/312), for second place in 79%, and for all three placings simultaneously in 61%. Disagreement, where it occurred, clustered in classes stewards independently flagged as close-run on the bench.

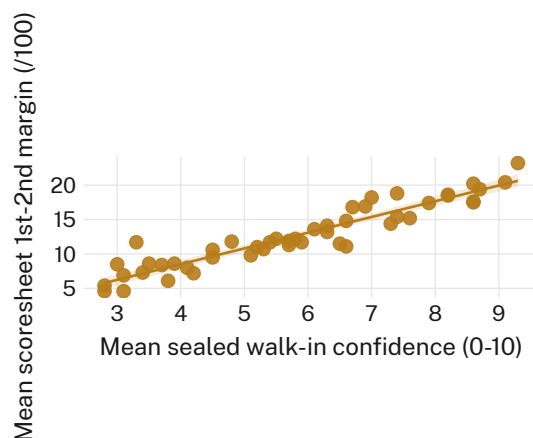


Figure 1: A judge’s mean sealed walk-in confidence in their first-place call predicts their mean scoresheet first-second margin closely ($r = 0.94$, $n = 47$ judges); the rubric’s numeric spread tracks a judgement recorded before the rubric was opened.

The relationship in Figure 1 holds judge by judge rather than only in aggregate: judges whose walk-in confidence averaged below 4 produced scoresheet margins averaging under nine points, against margins averaging over eighteen for judges averaging above 8 — roughly double, for roughly double the stated confidence.

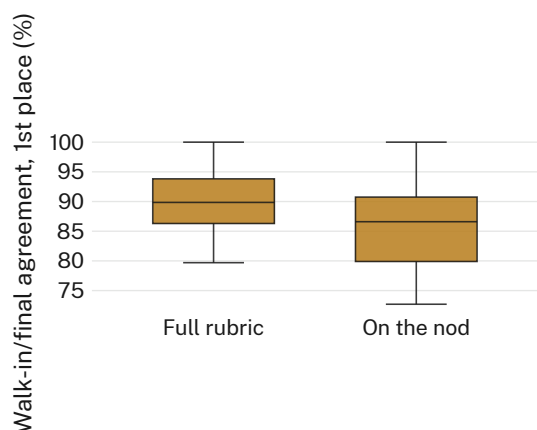


Figure 2: Walk-in/final agreement for first place, by whether stewards logged the judge as completing every rubric column (“Full rubric”) or moving directly to a total (“On the nod”). The two distributions — the column requirement’s entire stated purpose is to separate them — overlap almost completely.

The ablation in Figure 2 changes almost nothing. Mean agreement was 89.5% among the 28 judges logged completing every column and 85.6% among the 19 logged judging on the nod, a gap of well under four percentage points and, on a two-sample comparison, not distinguishable from noise (n.s.). We retain the full-column requirement in the show program’s judging guidelines — and in our own reported protocol — for completeness, and because no show society in the sample records an alternative instrument to compare it against.

Section-by-section, the pattern held most tightly in cut flowers (94% first-place agreement) and loosest in preserves and pickles (81%), the section stewards described, unprompted, as the one where entries “can still turn in the jar” between the walk and the scoresheet — the one section, notably, where the object of judgement is not yet in its final state at the moment the walk-in slip is sealed.

Discussion

Two independent measures point the same way. A judge’s own stated confidence in a walk-in call, sealed before the scoresheet is touched, predicts the eventual scoresheet margin about as closely as one field measurement typically predicts another it did not cause; and completing the scoresheet’s full column structure, rather than moving straight to a total, does not detectably change how often the finished placing matches the walk. Neither result shows the

scoresheet decides nothing — disagreement is real in a minority of classes, concentrated in exactly the section where an entry’s condition can still change between the walk and the paperwork — but together they suggest the rubric’s chief work, in the great majority of classes, is recording a placing a judge has already reached rather than deriving one the walk had left open.

This sits comfortably alongside a broader pattern in formal-assessment settings, where an instrument’s published criteria and the judgement actually doing the deciding are shown to diverge without either party acting in bad faith [1], [10]. Nothing here suggests a show society’s judges apply their scoresheet carelessly; every class in the sample received a fully reasoned, fully completed — or fully considered — scoresheet. It suggests only that a documented instrument and an operative one are not guaranteed to be the same instrument, even one completed, column by column, exactly as the show program’s own guidelines require.

Limitations

The sample draws from one show season and one state’s show circuit; a second season or a second state’s societies, with different scoresheet weightings, might surface a rubric effect this study’s ceiling cannot rule out, though the consistency of the confidence-margin relationship across all five sections suggests the result is not an artefact of one section’s judging culture. Rubric-fidelity grouping relied on steward logging rather than direct observation of every class, which may undercount brief lapses into full-column judging among the on-the-nod group; any such undercount would work against, not toward, the ablation’s null result. The walk-in slip itself may have sharpened judges’ first impressions simply by asking for them, a measurement effect we cannot separate from the underlying judging practice with this design alone.

Conclusion

A scoresheet can be published, completed in full, and genuinely present at every placing decision without being the thing that decides. Across 312 produce classes judged by 47 show-society judges over one season, a sealed walk-in expectation predicted the completed rubric’s outcome closely, and requiring every rubric col-

umn to be filled did not measurably change how often the two agreed. The instrument, on this evidence, formalises a placing more often than it produces one. Future work might extend the sealed-slip protocol to grand-champion judging, where a single across-section ranking compounds whatever the section scoresheets are or are not contributing, and to the stewards themselves, whose own sense of which classes run “close” this study borrowed but did not test.

Prior Slop University work has examined the same gap from the panel side: an Evaluation-of-Evaluation panel’s own scores moved with an added summary chart despite identical case content [16], and a shortlisting instrument’s recorded winner flipped in over a third of its narrowest margins under reversed presentation order [17]. The present survey extends that finding to a single judge’s rubric, in a setting entirely outside the University’s own walls.

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